
DECISION RECORD

Strategy Pivot — From Scale Engine to Audience Discovery

Decision record: what changed after the first nine pillars, and why.

Respect the Funk · marketing engine research program

Target: *Losing Sleep* — Hallow Youth · 15 July 2026

125 lines · 0 source links

Strategy pivot — from scale engine to audience-discovery engine

Date: 2026-07-15 **Status:** Supersedes the framing in the original brief. Pillars 01–09 remain valid as *reference*; their emphasis is wrong.

What changed

The first nine pillars researched a **global, scalable, multi-tenant publishing engine**. That was the brief. It is not the strategy.

The actual strategy: a small roster of artists. Quality and intelligent spend over quantity and scalability. Take an artist's music, cut it up, find their niche, identify *who* actually likes it, index creators whose audiences match, and test demographic hypotheses with a small network of owned content accounts that post daily — then use what's learned to target ads and seed creators.

In the user's words:

"we chart all types of listeners onto a modulus repeatable circle... equidistant apart like a clock, 12 parameters can define your position... so making a math page to attract men followers or a baby page to attract women... songs are found by ugc content, how can we tap into that network? how can we inspire natural ugc creators to use our audio?"

Why this is a better strategy than the one we researched

1. It dodges the measurement wall

The single biggest finding of Pillars 02/03/08/09 was that **causal attribution is impossible**: Spotify is third-party, no verified-stream event exists, smart-links expose clicks only, Spotify for Artists has no public API, and Facebook itself — with 663 RCTs and full internal data — was "unable to reliably estimate an ad campaign's causal effect."

That wall blocks *causal* questions ("did this ad cause that stream?"). It does **not** block *comparative* questions ("which of these six audiences responds most?"). **The pivot asks a question the available data can actually answer.** Comparison across probes is tractable, cheap, and mostly organic.

This is the difference between a strategy that fails on contact with the evidence and one that doesn't.

2. It manufactures the only targeting lever Meta left

Pillar 02: Meta **deprecated manual artist/genre interest targeting in January 2026**. "Target fans of similar artists" — the backbone of music advertising — is gone. Advantage+ is the only path.

What survives is **first-party data** → **Custom Audiences** → **Lookalike seeds**. A niche account that accumulates real engagers in a demographic is *manufacturing seed data* — the one input Meta still accepts and can't generate for us.

This reframes the probe accounts from a testbed into a durable asset. Even a probe that answers its question "wrong" leaves behind a seedable audience.

3. It attacks the only mechanism that produces streams without buying them

Pillars 02/04/08 established that buying 100k streams costs ~\$20–25K to produce ~\$300–500 of royalties — a ****~50x loss**** at any geo or bid strategy. Paid ads cannot be the engine; they can only be an amplifier.

Organic UGC adoption is the only mechanism with non-negative economics. "How do we inspire natural creators to use our audio" is therefore the most important question in the project, and it was underweighted in the original nine pillars.

The risk this introduces — decide it deliberately

"Demographic-based managed accounts" is ambiguous between two structures with opposite risk profiles.

	BRANDED NICHE CHANNEL	FAKE FAN PERSONA
What it is	An owned, themed content account (a math page, a baby page) that is a real channel	An account posing as an independent fan/person
Platform status	Explicitly fine. Meta requires no App Review to publish to accounts your own business owns	Inauthentic behavior. The exact trigger for enforcement
Consequence	None	Cascade to Business Manager + ad account (Meta's written Account Integrity policy), inferred via device/IP/payment fingerprinting

Every pillar independently found the same line: **the platforms police deception, not automation.** Automating accounts you own and disclose is permitted. Pretending to be someone you're not is not.

Pillar 05 found "fan-page networks" are routinely undisclosed paid promo, and that per NPR (13 July 2026) labels *routinely instruct creators not to disclose* — so "do what the majors do" is not a compliance strategy; the majors are non-compliant. FTC penalty: **\$53,088 per violation.**

Decision required: build the branded-channel version. It delivers everything the strategy needs with none of the cascade exposure. The distinction must be designed in now, not discovered later — drift is the failure mode.

The circular audience model — honest assessment

The instinct has real precedent

What's being described is a **circumplex**: positions on a circle where adjacent = similar and opposite = maximally different. This is an empirically validated structure in psychology — **Holland's RIASEC hexagon** (vocational interests), **Russell's circumplex of affect** (valence × arousal), the **interpersonal circumplex** (dominance × warmth). If the structure is real, **circular statistics** (von Mises distributions, circular means, Rayleigh tests) is the correct and well-developed toolkit.

This is not a naïve idea. It's a hypothesis with a literature.

Three problems, in order of severity

1. N. This is the binding constraint. Twelve equidistant positions is twelve parameters. We will have **4–10 probe accounts** and one artist. You cannot fit a 12-position model on 8 noisy observations — you would be reading structure out of noise, *which is the exact failure mode Pillar 03 found everywhere else in this project*. Pillar 12 is computing what's actually fittable; the expected answer is **1–2 axes (2–4 quadrants)**, with resolution earned by evidence rather than assumed.

The clock can be the destination. It cannot be the starting point.

2. Circularity must be discovered, not imposed. A clock face is a 2D embedding read in polar coordinates. Circular topology makes a strong empirical claim — that the space *wraps*, that traveling far enough returns you to the start. Whether audience space genuinely wraps is a testable question (Hubert & Arabie randomization tests, Browne's CIRCUM), not an assumption. Imposing a circle on non-circular structure produces confident nonsense.

3. Equidistant $\neq$ equal density. Real audience density is wildly lumpy — some sectors enormous, some empty. A clock face is a good *interface* metaphor sitting on a very non-uniform distribution. Don't let the visual regularity imply real regularity.

The strategic reframe that makes it worth doing

The circle is not a targeting tool. It's a creative-strategy tool.

Meta's GEM/Andromeda/Lattice stack already models audiences on data we will never have. We cannot out-model it for targeting, and Pillar 09's verdict stands: *"You cannot out-model Meta using a strict subset of Meta's data."*

But **Meta's optimizer cannot tell us what to make or whom to seed.** "This artist indexes toward the intense/sophisticated sector → make this content, brief these creators, spin up these probe accounts" is a question no ad platform will ever answer. That is a real, defensible role for an explicit, interpretable audience model — and it's a role that *doesn't compete with the black box*.

Targeting stays Meta's job. Creative direction becomes ours. The circle earns its place on the second, not the first.

| The confound that must be designed out

Each probe account differs in **both** its niche **and** its content quality. Raw follower growth confounds them — a "baby page" outgrowing a "math page" may mean the audience is better *or* that the content was better.

The fix is experimental design (rotating identical content across accounts, counterbalancing, within-account tests) and it only works if built in from the start. Pillar 12 is specifying the minimum viable design for ~6 accounts.

| The cost that isn't money

Organic growth is **slow**. The currency of this strategy is **weeks, not dollars** — which is precisely why the network must stay small and the hypotheses sharp. Pillar 11 is establishing realistic time-to-signal; if it comes back at 3–6 months, that changes the plan and needs to be known now rather than in month four.

New pillars commissioned

#	PILLAR	QUESTION
10	Creator indexing	How do we index creators by their <i>audience</i> 's demographics — and can that data be trusted?
11	Probe accounts	Where's the legitimacy line, how fast do niche accounts really grow, and can engagers seed lookalikes?
12	Audience geometry	Is the circumplex real, and what's actually fittable at N=6–10?
13	UGC adoption	How do we inspire natural creators to use our audio? The only mechanism with non-negative economics.

What carries forward unchanged

- Infrastructure is a rounding error (\$0/mo idle). **Still true, and now more so** — a small roster needs less.
- **Bought engagement: still no.** The EV math doesn't change with strategy.
- **Film-clip creative: still unadvertisable.** The rights verdict is independent of audience strategy.
- **Creative testing: \$143 for a +50% lift test.** Still the best-value instrument we have — and now the core of the method rather than a side tool.
- **CML clearance and the TikTok API audit** remain the two free clocks. **UGC adoption runs through TikTok, so CML clearance is now more load-bearing, not less.**